

EXCLUSIVE
FROM THE BATTLE ZONE

SRI LANKA

THE ARMED FORCES MAKE A DECISIVE ASSAULT ON THE LAST STRONGHOLDS OF THE LTTE AND HAVE ITS CHIEF WITHIN ITS SIGHTS. BUT HE IS A WILY FOE AND CAPABLE OF SURPRISES.

CORNERING

■ **By Raj Chengappa at the Mallawi front**

It's only when you fly over the Wanni jungle do you begin to understand why it's taken the Sri Lankan armed forces months to wrest territory from the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). And why despite launching a decisive assault to recapture the crucial city of Kilinochchi, the LTTE's headquarters in the northern province, the security forces have made slow progress. They are still some 10 km from the main town which they had planned to take before they got bogged down by the north-east monsoon that has just set in.

The trees of the surrounding tropical jungle soar to over 60 ft in many places and the canopy is so thick and dense that even sunlight finds it difficult to penetrate. These are the jungles that the LTTE has made its second home, melting into greenery whenever there is a major assault and setting up deadly booby traps and ambushes for government troops in pursuit.

It's the reason why the Sri Lankan Air Force Bell 212 helicopter flies at tree-top height right through the 40-minute-ride from Anuradhapura to the frontlines of the battle. As Squadron Leader Dakshin Pereira explained later, "If we fly higher we become sitting ducks to sniper fire—it gives the terrorists time to aim and shoot. When we fly



AP PHOTO/LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL EELAM, HD